

MASTER'S THESIS MANUAL edition 2025-27

Coordinated by **Víctor Gómez Frías**

(victor.gomez.frias@upm.es), IMIM programme director

Introduction

- Master's thesis (MT) represents 30 ECTS, about 750 working hours.
- Corresponds to IMIM's 4th semester but can be started from the 3rd semester.
- Triple objective:
 - apply learning acquisitions from different courses,
 - develop research abilities (synthesis and analytical capacities, writing skills),
 - support professional integration.
- Outcome: a research study (about 70 pages) + a jury defence (15-minutes presentation followed by questions).
- Originality and intellectual integrity are a strict requisite. Plagiarism or other failures would imply a 0 (F) in the master thesis and disciplinary measures.
- The research field can be the students' internship or job, which means use it as the case study for a scientific approach (develop deep knowledge and understanding of organisational phenomena and solving problems), but the outcome cannot only consist in a description of this professional experience.
- Accordingly, there are two master's thesis modalities:
 - Professional oriented: more empirical field of study linked with student's internship or job,
 - Academic: more theoretical field of study often suggested by an IMIM professor.

Assignment and supervision process

- Before Feb 5, 2027: students fill a Moodle questionnaire (will be sent in autumn) about their preference for a professional or academic modality.
 - If professional: indicate internship/job company and position and possible field of study,
 - If academic: indicate disciplinary preference and if you have already discussed with any professor.
- If necessary, the programme director will ask the students more by email/videoconference about their interests.
- Before end of February 2027: the programme director will assign/confirm the tutor for each student.
- The students will keep regular contact with their tutors: firstly to define the thesis' object and then to ask them for orientations and confirm their research choices and thesis drafting.
 - The interaction will be pushed by the demand of the students, who are responsible of their work progress.
 - As an orientation, a monthly interaction either by meeting, partial deliverables or drafts can be a good basis throughout the process.
- Tutors will be asked by the programme director in February to inform about their students' progress.

Defences

- In order to be allowed to defend their thesis, students need to validate previously all subjects and any other academic and administrative requisite, such as the fees payments.
- Students willing to participate in each of the three defences' period have to upload their thesis in Moodle before the limit date. The programme director will then ask the tutors if the MT stands for the quality requirements to authorise their defence and will confirm the time for those approved.

Students upload their thesis in Moodle	Confirmation of students qualified and defence's times	Defence's date (might be adjusted in autumn)	HWU diploma ready from
Apr 19	Apr 29	May 6	June
Jun 8	Jun 18	Jun 25	October
Sep 7	Sep 17	Sep 24	October

- Defence's will be hold in person in Madrid. Student's who are not living in Madrid may exceptionally apply for an online defence at the moment of uploading their thesis.
- The evaluation will be based on the scientific rigor, originality, results' relevance, quality of writing, amount of work, and communication skills at the defence. The tutor will establish a qualitative and quantitative report based on these criteria except the last one. The jury will establish the master's thesis grade based on all these criteria and the tutor's report.
- After a successful MT defence, students will receive a certificate of the IMIM completion. A graduation ceremony will be organised in Madrid on Sep 25 in which the successful students will receive an honorific document.
 - The UPM diploma production will be started after each defence's period; after some months, the students will be notified in order to collect it or receive it by mail.
 - The HWU diploma production is determined by a graduation committee generally hold twice a year (by mid May and mid October) which means that only the IMIM first defence's period will qualify for the June graduation ceremony in Edinburgh. Students can ask for the HWU diploma in absentia: <https://www.hw.ac.uk/students/manage-your-studies/graduation/graduating-in-absentia>

Suggested master thesis' structure

- Cover page (see Annex "Front Page of the Thesis")
- Acknowledgments (optional)
- Conflict of Interest (if applicable)
- Extended Abstract (~1,000 words): objective(s), context and theoretical background; methodology; main findings; short discussion of the results; short conclusion; and contributions.
- Keywords (maximum of six) and UNESCO codes
- Table of Contents (paginated)
- List of Tables and Figures (paginated)
- Theoretical basis (>3,000 words): that demonstrates a clear understanding of how the specific theories or conceptual frameworks used in the research apply to their thesis, including precise definitions of the key concepts involved.
- Methodology (>3,000 words): a solid grasp of the chosen methodology, with clear justification for each method in relation to the research objectives. It

should outline the methods used, data sources, collection and analysis techniques, concept measurement, and address reliability and validity. Methodological limitations must also be critically evaluated.

- Findings/Results (>4,000 words): research findings in direct relation to the stated objectives or questions. The student should clearly and analytically report the results of the qualitative and/or quantitative data analysis, focusing only on insights that address the research aims.
- Discussion (>3,000 words): interpretation of the findings in relation to existing literature and theoretical frameworks. It is where the student clearly addresses the research objectives or questions through a synthesis of the results and established knowledge.
- Conclusions/Contributions/Implications (>1,000 words): this/these section/s should indicate how and to what extent the research objectives have been met. No new material or references should be introduced. The conclusion summarizes the discussion and highlights the broader significance of the thesis. The student should clearly present the theoretical, methodological, and contextual contributions of the research, along with its implications for policy-makers, industry, and future research.
- List of References: all citations made in writing the Thesis (direct quotations or paraphrasing) should be included. The APA, Harvard or Chicago Style for citation and list references can be used. Scientific journal publications are the mostly recommended references to be used in the Thesis.
- Abbreviations, units, and acronyms
- Glossary (optional)
- Appendices (if applicable)

Annex: Front Page of the Thesis



Title of the Thesis

Edition, 2024 – 2026

Author:

Student's name

Master's Thesis Tutor:

Tutors' name

Month and year

